‘It is an avowed policy of the United States that we will never strike first with nuclear weapons,’ President Muffley insists to General Turgidson. President Kennedy and Premier Khrushchev made similar statements. At other times, they said the opposite. What was the reality? Robert McNamara was adamant that the American presidents he served would not fire first. In 1983 he wrote that, ‘in long private conversations with successive Presidents – Kennedy and Johnson – I recommended, without qualification, that they never initiate, under any circumstances, the use of nuclear weapons. I believe they accepted my recommendation.’[8]

Yet, as noted earlier, McGeorge Bundy did not know what Kennedy would have done over West Berlin had he faced the ‘moment of thermonuclear truth’. One possible answer emerges from British records. Major-General Sir Kenneth Strong was Director-General of the Joint Intelligence Bureau (and member of the Joint Intelligence Committee). By coincidence, he was in Washington between 13 and 25 October and was one of the British officials briefed by CIA about the MRBMs on 19 October. Strong was well-connected and well-thought of in Washington. He had been Eisenhower’s G-2 in the Normandy campaign (and Ike reportedly considered appointing him as Director of the CIA).

On 25 October 1962 DCI McCone briefed General Strong before his return to the UK.[9] The director of the JIB subsequently provided the Prime Minster and Foreign Secretary with an account of his experiences. He told Macmillan and Home that, ‘if the Soviets had reacted against any action in Cuba by moving against Berlin,’ Washington was ‘prepared to go it alone either without consulting their allies or irrespective of what their allies said.’[10] Strong ‘thought that the American Government were prepared for their action in Cuba to escalate into the nuclear’. This escalation was not limited to tactical nuclear weapons. Strong said that ‘it seemed to him that the US Administration was overconfident that they had pinpointed the position of all the main sites of inter-continental ballistic missiles in the Soviet Union, and they hoped they would be able to take these out with a pre-emptive attack by their bombers’. This clearly alarmed Macmillan and Home, who worried the whereabouts of all the Soviet ICBMs might not be known.